



ROCKS



Movements in the Earth's crust are slowly changing the rocks that make up the surface of our planet. Mountains are pushed up and weathered

away, and the fragments moved and made into other rocks. These rocks may be dragged down into the mantle and melted by its fierce heat. When a volcano erupts, the melted rock is thrown to the surface as lava, which cools and hardens as rock. This is broken down by weathering, and so the cycle starts again.

In the beginning

Rocks belong to three basic types. Igneous rocks are made from magma or lava. The word igneous means "fiery." Sedimentary rocks are made in layers from broken rocks. Metamorphic rocks can start off as any type. They are changed by heat and weight and the word metamorphic means "changed."



Sedimentary rocks

These are made from bits of rock and plant and animal remains. They are broken into fine pieces and carried by rivers into the sea. They pile up in layers and press together to make solid rock.

The Painted Desert, in Arizona, is made of sedimentary rocks.



Limestone



Conglomerate



Red sandstone

In time, material moved by rivers and piled up in the sea will become sedimentary rocks.

Rock fragments called sediments are carried by rivers, glaciers, the wind, and the sea.

